

Chicago Tribune



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FRIDAY, DECEMBER 26, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

U.S. SENATE RACE

Democratic campaign starts in slow motion

Race to replace Durbin struggles to break into crowded news cycle

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

The top-of-the-ticket Illinois Democratic primary race for the state's open U.S. Senate seat has lurched along in slow motion through much of the fall, its major candidates eclipsed largely by a turbulent political backdrop even as they seek support for a contest less than 90 days away.

But as the March 17 election moves closer, signs of chippiness have emerged among the contenders as they look to move beyond well-worn campaign rhetoric and seek to draw sharper contrasts for voters.

The race to replace retiring U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin has struggled to break through a crowded news cycle. A tumultuous fall — punctuated by aggressive immigration enforcement raids in the Chicago area under Republican President Donald Trump and a bruising fight over the city budget — has dominated political attention, leaving the candidates to build momentum primarily on their own.

So far, U.S. Reps. Raja Krishnamoorthi of Schaumburg, Robin Kelly of Lynwood and Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton of Chicago have focused on similar public themes — affordability, health care and opposition to Trump — while shying away from direct criticism of one another in early public forums.

They've also worked on fundraising and building support, seeking backing from individual labor unions after none of them could get the two-thirds support from delegates needed to win the Illinois AFL-CIO's endorsement.

At the same time, the campaigns have begun taking shots at each other on more political issues, focusing on campaign finances rather than policy, to try to dust up the rival contenders.

Already, a Stratton has been filed against Stratton, alleging her Senate campaign misused an email fundraising list from her state campaign, something her Senate campaign dismisses as "frivolous."

The complaint, filed by a family member associated with a Krish-

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Janice McLee shuffles her position in her seat as a homeless man tries to get passengers' attention on a CTA Blue Line train to Forest Park on Dec. 16 in Chicago. JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

High-profile incidents belie CTA crime rates

Riders rattled by violent events, but chances of becoming victim are very small

By Caroline Kubzansky and Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

Just past midnight days before Christmas, Chicago police boarded a Pink Line train at Washington and Wells streets and found two men shot.

A knife fight had escalated to a shooting that left one of the men dead, police said.

Such recent cases of violence aboard the system have rattled some riders while also drawing attention from Trump administration officials looking to make a point about crime in Democratic-run cities like Chicago.

But each time someone boards

a CTA bus or train, their chances of becoming a victim of or even witnessing any kind of violent crime that results in serious physical harm to a person — a shooting, a murder — is very small, statistics reviewed by the Tribune show.

The Dec. 23 Pink Line homicide was the eighth killing in the city on the CTA in 2025, according to Chicago Police Department data. CPD recorded six homicides on the system through Dec. 24 last year, but that count doesn't reflect a mass shooting that killed four people on a Forest Park-bound Blue Line train outside city limits in September 2024.

CTA riders took more than a million bus and train trips on a single average weekday, according to the system's most recently available ridership data. In other words, CTA riders are far more likely than not to reach their destinations safely.

Violent crime aboard the system is down, mirroring dips across the city and country. CPD data collected through Dec. 21 shows that FBI-classified violent crimes like robberies and shooting incidents on CTA buses, trains and properties have decreased by about 5% between 2024 and 2025. Between 2022 and 2025, data shows there's been a roughly 10% drop.

But violent crime is still higher overall than it was pre-pandemic, a fact that has vexed transit and city officials for years as they have struggled to make the system safer. In 2019, city data showed there were two homicides on the system in the city limits and five nonfatal shootings.

Last month, a particularly horrific and apparently random attack in which a woman was doused in gasoline and lit on fire while riding the CTA Blue Line in downtown Chicago reanimated conversations about violent crime on the city's transit system.

The attack, which the woman,

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INSIDE



DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Navy recruits get a taste of home

Navy recruit Amber Rens, of Wisconsin, right, introduces her friend and fellow recruit Rae Inting, of Florida, to her parents on the phone on Thursday at Christian Liberty Academy in Arlington Heights. It was the 13th year that the school hosted recruits from Naval Station Great Lakes on Christmas. Recruits are not allowed unlimited phone calls on base but were allowed to use the phones for the day to talk to loved ones. Page 5

A FATHER'S LEGACY: As Ozzy Trapilo follows in his father's footsteps, from playing at Boston College to making the NFL, is he the Bears' left tackle of the future? **Chicago Sports**

NEW SCRUTINY: Days after Ghislaine Maxwell asked a judge to free her from a 20-year prison sentence, the public release of transcripts from her sex trafficking case returned to the spotlight. **Nation & World**

Even methane-belching cows can be part of climate solution

Sustainable, innovative practices can offer wins in fight against warming

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Illinois is a top agricultural state, generating billions of dollars annually, but even where stalks of corn and acres of soybean vastly outnumber its 400,000 head of cattle, cows raised for beef and dairy account for an outsize portion of the industry's methane emissions.

A single cow raised for meat produces between 154 and 264 pounds of methane per year, according to the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency, meaning 333,000 beef cattle in Illinois last year could have released between 51 million and 88 million pounds of methane into the atmosphere. This is equivalent to emissions from 151,000 to 260,700 gasoline-powered cars driven in one year.

Cattle produce this powerful, heat-trapping gas through a digestive process called enteric fermentation, which represents over 25% of greenhouse gas emissions from the agricultural sector.



Abigail, left, and other cows rest and feed on a mixture of ground corn, corn gluten, wheat middlings, cereal grains and other ingredients at Lenkaitis Holsteins Dairy Farm in Campton Hills on Aug. 28. The Lenkaitis' 80 Holstein cows are housed in a state-of-the-art barn with technology that ensures productivity and sustainability for both the business and its environmental impact. DOMINIC DI PALERMO/TRIBUNE

As climate change from human activities intensifies, experts say addressing this source of emissions by implementing sustainable and innovative practices — from diet additives to regenerative grazing — can offer quick wins in the fight against global rising temperatures, which is already presenting new chal-

lenges to raising cattle.

Cows can spend over eight hours a day regurgitating their partially digested meals to chew again. As bacteria break down food in a specialized stomach, the process releases methane, which cows then belch into the air. It's

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TODAY'S WEATHER



High 49 Low 37

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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